

History of Economic Thought

ECO 4343 & 5343

CRN 49406 (4343) · CRN 37336 (5343)

Tuesday & Thursday, 2:00–3:15 pm

Foster 402

August 25 – December 8, 2026

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Hours: Tue 3:30–4:45 pm

Wed 9:00–10:15 am

Does market exchange harmonize our interests, or conceal a conflict between them?

That is the question this course asks, every week, of every writer we read. Smith's invisible hand, Ricardo's rents, Bentham's calculus, Bastiat's harmonies, Mill's hesitation, Marx's exploitation, and the marginalists' quiet decision to stop asking are all answers to it. By December you will be able to say where each of them lands, and why.

What this course is

Economics became a specialized field over several hundred years. Many of its ideas came and went; many were absorbed, in some altered shape, into what you are taught today. This class is a slow walk through the period when the foundations were laid — roughly from the merchants and pamphleteers who preceded Adam Smith, through Smith, Malthus, Ricardo, Bentham, Mill, and Marx, and ending at the marginalist turn of the 1870s.

We stop before 1900. This is deliberate. A survey that sprints from Aristotle to Keynes teaches you a list of names; I would rather you read a small number of difficult writers closely enough to argue with them.

What you will be able to do in December

Not “understand economic thought.” Five specific things you cannot do today.

1. **Reconstruct.** Read a classical argument in the man's own words and name the one assumption that, pulled out, collapses his conclusion.
2. **Compute.** Derive Ricardian rent by hand. Find where trade stops paying. Get a rate of profit out of s , c , and v . On paper, in ten minutes.
3. **Formalize.** Turn a verbal argument into variables, parameters, and a rule that says how the thing moves.
4. **Find the boundary.** Show me the setting where the famous result reverses or vanishes, and name the assumption that was holding it up.

5. **Place it.** Say where a writer lands on the question above — and point at the feature of his *model*, not his politics, that puts him there.

The book

E.K. Hunt and Mark Lautzenheiser, *History of Economic Thought: A Critical Perspective*, 3rd edition. This is the only book you must buy, and the 3rd edition is the newest one — do not pay extra hunting for a later one. It is published by M.E. Sharpe and reissued by Routledge; either printing is fine.

It runs about \$43 new on Amazon (ISBN 0-7656-2599-7). **See Canvas for more information about getting a copy.**

Buy it. Until yours arrives, I will post the PDF on Canvas so nobody falls behind waiting on shipping. That is a bridge, not a substitute. You will be quoting this book by page number all semester, and that is far easier in a physical copy you can mark up.

Additional readings, when I assign them, go on Canvas.

An AI coding agent (also required)

You will need an account with **Claude** (<https://claude.ai>) or **Codex** (through ChatGPT, <https://chatgpt.com>). The paid tier, around \$20 a month, is what you want.

Treat this like the book: it is a required material for the course, and you should budget for it. If you would rather use a different coding agent, bring it to me and we will almost certainly say yes — I care that you have one, not which one. If the cost is a real problem for you, come see me early and privately and we will find a way. What will not work is showing up in October without one, because six times this semester you are going to build with it.

How you are graded

Component	Weight	When
Tuesday quizzes	20%	Every Tuesday, at 2:02 pm sharp
Model builds	30%	Six, every other Thursday
Midterm	20%	Thursday, October 1
Final	30%	Tuesday, December 8

90–100	A	70–79.99	C
80–89.99	B	60–69.99	D
		below 60	F

Tuesday quizzes — 20%

Ten minutes, on paper, scantron. I hand them out at **2:02 pm** and collect them at **2:12 pm**. If you arrive at 2:05 you get seven minutes. If you arrive at 2:15 you get a zero. There are no makeups, ever, for any reason — and because there are no makeups, **I drop your two lowest scores**, no questions asked and no note from anyone required. Use them on the day your car dies. That is what they are for.

The quiz is on the reading, not on my lecture, and it is given before I have said anything. Bring the book.

Model builds — 30%

Every economist we read built a machine. Malthus built one that takes a wage and returns a population. Ricardo built one that takes a plot of land and returns a rent. They built these out of sentences, because sentences were what they had, and then they ran the machines in their heads.

Six times this semester, you will run one. You will work the numbers out by hand on paper, then have an AI coding agent build a small interactive model of that mechanism, then check the model against your own arithmetic. One HTML page each time, accumulating into a single site.

I grade one thing: **do the model's numbers match the numbers you worked out by hand?** The full assignment is a separate document. Read it before the first build.

Midterm and final — 50%

Essay format. The midterm covers chapters 1–4 and is on **Thursday, October 1**. The final is on **Tuesday, December 8** — the last day of class, not finals week — and is cumulative with weight on the second half.

I am doing it this way on purpose. When you sit down in December to plan a brutal week, this course will already be finished. Mine is not one you have to carry into finals.

If you miss the midterm for any reason, the final counts for both.

On artificial intelligence in this course

I am going to require you to build things with an AI agent. I am also going to give you a quiz every Tuesday morning that no AI can help you with. Let me say plainly why those are not two policies but one.

You may delegate what you can specify and verify. You may not delegate what you cannot.

Tuesday is where you prove you have read a text with your own eyes and can turn a crank with your own pencil. The builds are where you spend that capacity. A student who cannot compute Ricardian rent on paper is not the manager of an agent — he is a person watching one work, and later, when something is wrong, he will be a person who cannot tell.

Two years ago students in this class scored ChatGPT's citations for whether they actually existed. I used to put it this way: imagine you are a boss, an employee hands you a report, you sign it, and the citations turn out to be fake. Whose fault is that? Yours. You signed it. Nothing about that has changed. We have only raised the stakes from a citation to a working model.

And this is not a management seminar that wandered into a history course. We will spend a month on the division of labor. Smith takes you into a pin factory and shows you ten men making forty-eight thousand pins in a day, where one man alone could barely make twenty — the most famous argument for specialization ever written. Then, four books later, Smith tells you what happens to the man who performs one operation his whole life. Marx picks up that exact thread and gives it another name. So does Mill.

This course walks from the division of labor to alienation and then hands you an agent to divide your own labor with. That is the experiment, and you are in it. Tuesday is the portion of the work that cannot be

divided.

What is not allowed: using an AI to answer for you on a quiz or an exam, or submitting a build whose arithmetic you did not do yourself. Everything else is a matter of judgment, and developing that judgment is part of the course.

Electronics

No laptops or tablets during class. The research on this is consistent — students who take notes by hand outperform students who type, and screens degrade comprehension for the people sitting near them as well as for the user. If you have a documented need for a device, come see me in office hours and we will arrange it.

You will be building websites for this class. You will not be building them at 2 pm on a Tuesday.

Schedule

Chapters are Hunt & Lautzenheiser. Read the chapter *before* the Tuesday it appears.

Builds are due Thursday at 11:59 pm. Italicized dates and dates marked * are days I am away.

Wk	Tue	Thu	Topic	Ch	Due
1	Aug 25	Aug 27	Introduction; feudalism to capitalism	1	
2	Sep 1	Sep 3	Before Smith: mercantilism, Physiocrats	2	
3	Sep 8	Sep 10 <i>cov.</i>	Adam Smith I	3	
4	Sep 15	Sep 17 <i>cov.</i>	Adam Smith II	3	
5	Sep 22	Sep 24	Malthus	4	Build 1
6	Sep 29 *	Oct 1	MIDTERM (ch. 1–4)		
7	Oct 6	Oct 8	Ricardo I: value, rent	5	Build 2
8	Oct 13	Oct 15	Ricardo II: distribution, trade	5	
9	Oct 20	Oct 22	Bentham, Say, and Senior	6	Build 3
10	Oct 27	Oct 29	Thompson and Hodgskin	7	
11	Nov 3 *	Nov 5 *	Bastiat and Mill	8	
12	Nov 10	Nov 12	Bastiat and Mill, cont'd	8	Build 4
13	Nov 17	Nov 19	Marx I: value, labor power	9	Build 5
14	Nov 24	Nov 26	Thanksgiving — no class		
15	Dec 1	Dec 3	Marx II; Jevons, Menger, Walras	9–10	Build 6
16	Dec 8		FINAL EXAM		

A note about my travel

I am away for a handful of class days this fall: a keynote in Milan, a seminar talk at Syracuse, a seminar talk in Boston, and a hackathon at Amazon.

None of those days are lost. Some will be taught by a colleague, one of them is the midterm, and the rest will run asynchronously — I will post what you need and you will do the work on your own time. I will tell you which is which well before each one, and the reading schedule does not change either way.

This schedule is tentative in the way all schedules are. If we need an extra day on Ricardo, we will take it from

somewhere else, and I will tell you in advance.

University policies

Academic integrity

All students must abide by Baylor's Honor Code, <https://www.baylor.edu/honorcode>. A student who commits academic dishonesty disrespects the work of his classmates. If you fall behind and feel tempted, come see me first — we will find a way for you to turn work in late with a penalty, which is always better than the alternative.

Students with disabilities

Any student who needs learning accommodations should tell me at the beginning of the semester. Obtain documentation from the Office of Access and Learning Accommodation (OALA), Paul L. Foster Success Center, Sid Richardson Room 190, (254) 710-3605, and bring it to me early.

Title IX

Baylor does not discriminate on the basis of sex or gender and does not tolerate harassment on those grounds. If you or someone you know would like help related to sexual or gender-based harassment, sexual assault, exploitation, stalking, intimate partner violence, or retaliation for reporting, contact the Title IX Office at (254) 710-8454 or report online at <https://www.baylor.edu/titleix>. The office can explain your options and connect you to counseling, medical, academic, and housing support. You are not required to share your experience.

Lauren's Promise

Lauren McCluskey, a 21-year-old honors student and athlete at the University of Utah, was murdered on October 22, 2018, by a stalker. Lauren's Promise is my promise to *listen and believe you if someone is threatening you*.

If you are in immediate danger, call 911. Baylor Police: (254) 710-2222. Counseling Center: (254) 710-2467. Health Services: (254) 710-1010. Or tell me, and I will connect you to help.

Last revised August 24, 2026. This syllabus may change; I will announce any change in class and on Canvas.